Paper 3: Conflict at Home and Abroad: the USA, 1954–75

"Why did the USA become militarily entangled in Vietnam, and why were US tactics unable to defeat the Vietcong?"

MASTERY PACK: KEY TOPIC 3: US INVOLVEMENT IN THE VIETNAM WAR, 1954–75

Operative / Student Name: _____

Target: Total Recall of 80 Crucial Questions

Interactive Recall Quiz & Scratch-Off Vault

Scan with your phone to launch Instant-Feedback Recall Quiz (#practice-mode) & tap-to-reveal self-marking solutions.

the-history-revision-hub.netlify.app/units/usa/mastery_pack_KT3.html#practice-mode

RESTRICTED ACCESS - MASTER YOUR MEMORY

How to Hack Your Memory

(Rules of Engagement)

1. Never Just Read

Reading the answers feels like learning, but it's an illusion. You must force your brain to struggle to find the answer. The struggle is what builds memory pathways.

2. Cover, Recall, Check

Cover the answer sheet. Write your answer down in the notes section (or say it out loud). Only then are you allowed to check 'The Vault'.

3. Track Your Threat Level

Use the R-A-G (Red, Amber, Green) checkboxes next to every question after you attempt it.

- 🟩 **Green:** I nailed it instantly.
- 🟨 **Amber:** I got it, but I had to think hard.
- 🟥 **Red:** My mind went blank. (Revisit these tomorrow).

4. The Interrogation (Homework Protocol)

True mastery requires testing under pressure. Hand 'The Vault' (answers) to your parent or guardian. They will test you on 20 random questions. They hold the score; they hold the signature.

5. The 3-Star Parent Effort Rubric

When authenticating your spaced retrieval practice on the final Mastery Tracker, your parent or guardian will evaluate your effort using the following criteria:

- ⭐ ⭐ ⭐ **3 Stars (Full Mastery):** Completed under strict exam conditions without glancing at notes or the Knowledge Vault. Total independent recall.
- ⭐ ⭐ **2 Stars (Consolidating):** Required 1–2 hints from the Knowledge Vault, but demonstrated sound foundational understanding.
- ⭐ **1 Star (Needs Intervention):** Rushed, mind went blank, or completed with notes open. Target facts must be hunted down and re-tested tomorrow.

KT 3.1: Why did the US support the unpopular government of Ngo Dinh Diem in South Vietnam?

Q#	The Target Question	R	A	G	Notes / My Answer
1	Who was the leader of the communist forces and President of North Vietnam?	☐	☐	☐	
2	Which 1954 battle saw the decisive defeat of the French army, ending French colonial rule in Indochina?	☐	☐	☐	
3	Which parallel divided Vietnam into North and South according to the 1954 Geneva Accords?	☐	☐	☐	
4	What theory did President Eisenhower use in 1954 to justify U.S. intervention in Southeast Asia?	☐	☐	☐	
5	Who was the first US president to send military advisors to South Vietnam?	☐	☐	☐	
6	Which US president increased the number of military advisors in Vietnam to over 16,000 by late 1963?	☐	☐	☐	
7	What was the capital city of South Vietnam?	☐	☐	☐	
8	What was the capital city of North Vietnam?	☐	☐	☐	
9	Which South Vietnamese president was overthrown and assassinated in a coup in November 1963?	☐	☐	☐	
10	What was the name of the program that built fortified villages to separate peasants from Vietcong influence?	☐	☐	☐	
11	What was the name of the communist-led nationalist coalition that fought the French for independence?	☐	☐	☐	
12	Which major religious group faced severe discrimination under Ngo Dinh Diem's Catholic-dominated government?	☐	☐	☐	

Q#	The Target Question	R	A	G	Notes / My Answer
13	Why did the Strategic Hamlet Program (1962) fail and actually increase support for the Vietcong?	☐	☐	☐	
14	What term was commonly used by US troops to refer to the communist insurgent fighters in South Vietnam?	☐	☐	☐	
15	What was the official name of the political and military organization commonly known as the Vietcong?	☐	☐	☐	
16	Which Buddhist monk committed self-immolation in Saigon in 1963 to protest Ngo Dinh Diem's religious persecution?	☐	☐	☐	
17	Which of the following best explains why the Domino Theory was central to US foreign policy in Southeast Asia?	☐	☐	☐	
18	What was the primary consequence of the French defeat at Dien Bien Phu in 1954?	☐	☐	☐	
19	Which of the following was a primary cause for the growth of the Vietcong (National Liberation Front) in South Vietnam by 1960?	☐	☐	☐	
20	What was the significance of the Strategic Hamlet Program introduced by Diem and the US in 1962?	☐	☐	☐	

MISSION DEBRIEF

Score: _____ / 20

Parent/Guardian Authentication (Signature): _____

Date: _____

KT 3.2: Why did the US send combat troops to Vietnam after the Gulf of Tonkin incident?

Q#	The Target Question	R	A	G	Notes / My Answer
21	Which US destroyer was reportedly attacked by North Vietnamese torpedo boats in August 1964?	☐	☐	☐	
22	Which congressional resolution in August 1964 gave President Johnson war powers to defend South Vietnam?	☐	☐	☐	
23	What was the main consequence of the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution?	☐	☐	☐	
24	What was the code name of the sustained US bombing campaign of North Vietnam started in early 1965?	☐	☐	☐	
25	What was the primary goal of Operation Rolling Thunder?	☐	☐	☐	
26	Who was the commander of US forces in Vietnam during the period of escalation (1964-68)?	☐	☐	☐	
27	Where did the first official US ground combat troops land in South Vietnam in 1965?	☐	☐	☐	
28	Which US military base in South Vietnam was attacked in February 1965, prompting Johnson to launch Rolling Thunder?	☐	☐	☐	
29	What was the peak troop level of US servicemen in Vietnam under President Johnson's administration?	☐	☐	☐	
30	Who was the Secretary of Defense who served under Kennedy and Johnson, overseeing the escalation of the war?	☐	☐	☐	
31	Why was the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution (1964) highly significant for US involvement in Vietnam?	☐	☐	☐	
32	Which South Vietnamese air base was the landing site for the first official US ground combat troops in March 1965?	☐	☐	☐	

Q#	The Target Question	R	A	G	Notes / My Answer
33	Which major battle in November 1965 was the first large-scale clash between the US Army and conventional NVA forces?	☐	☐	☐	
34	How many members of Congress voted against the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution in August 1964?	☐	☐	☐	
35	Who was the military commander of the North Vietnamese Army (NVA) who planned the strategy against the French and Americans?	☐	☐	☐	
36	How did declassified records later clarify the events of the Gulf of Tonkin Incident on 4 August 1964?	☐	☐	☐	
37	Which of the following best explains why the Gulf of Tonkin Resolution was a turning point in the Vietnam War?	☐	☐	☐	
38	What was a major consequence of the launch of Operation Rolling Thunder in 1965?	☐	☐	☐	
39	Which of the following was a primary cause for President Johnson's decision to deploy official US ground combat troops in early 1965?	☐	☐	☐	
40	Which of the following was a key consequence of General William Westmoreland's 'war of attrition' strategy?	☐	☐	☐	

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Date: _____

KT 3.3: Why did US military tactics (like bombing and search & destroy) fail to defeat the Vietcong?

Q#	The Target Question	R	A	G	Notes / My Answer
41	What Vietcong military tactic involved hit-and-run ambushes, traps, and avoiding conventional pitched battles?	☐	☐	☐	
42	What US military tactic involved patrolling the jungle to locate enemy units and calling in artillery and air strikes?	☐	☐	☐	
43	What highly flammable, sticky gasoline gel was used by the US military in bombs to burn jungle foliage and enemy positions?	☐	☐	☐	
44	What chemical herbicide was sprayed by US aircraft to defoliate forests and destroy enemy food crops?	☐	☐	☐	
45	What was the name of the complex supply route running from North to South Vietnam through Laos and Cambodia?	☐	☐	☐	
46	What underground structures did the Vietcong construct to hide, store supplies, and launch surprise attacks?	☐	☐	☐	
47	What simple Vietcong traps used sharpened bamboo stakes hidden in pits and smeared with excrement?	☐	☐	☐	
48	What metric did U.S. commanders use as the primary measure of progress in the war of attrition?	☐	☐	☐	
49	What helicopter model was widely used by the US for troop transport, medical evacuation, and gunship support?	☐	☐	☐	
50	Which major North Vietnamese and Vietcong offensive in January 1968 marked the turning point of the war?	☐	☐	☐	
51	Why was the 1968 Tet Offensive considered a major political turning	☐	☐	☐	

Q#	The Target Question	R	A	G	Notes / My Answer
	point for the US homefront?				
52	Which historic South Vietnamese city saw the longest and bloodiest urban battle of the Tet Offensive?	☐	☐	☐	
53	Which US Marine base in northern South Vietnam was besieged by NVA forces for 77 days in early 1968?	☐	☐	☐	
54	Which high-profile building in Saigon was attacked by a Vietcong commando squad during the Tet Offensive?	☐	☐	☐	
55	What slang term was used by US soldiers for search-and-destroy missions that ended in burning down peasant huts?	☐	☐	☐	
56	What was the approximate total length of the Ho Chi Minh Trail supply network running through Laos and Cambodia?	☐	☐	☐	
57	Which of the following best explains why the Ho Chi Minh Trail was crucial to the Vietcong's military strategy?	☐	☐	☐	
58	What was the primary consequence of the US military's heavy reliance on 'Search and Destroy' tactics?	☐	☐	☐	
59	Which of the following explains why the Vietcong's guerrilla tactics were so difficult for the US military to defeat?	☐	☐	☐	
60	What was a major consequence of the US military's use of chemical defoliants like Agent Orange and Napalm?	☐	☐	☐	

MISSION DEBRIEF

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KT 3.4: What was Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy, and did it achieve peace with honour?

Q#	The Target Question	R	A	G	Notes / My Answer
61	What policy under President Nixon aimed to withdraw US troops and hand over combat duties to the South Vietnamese army?	☐	☐	☐	
62	What was the name of the foreign policy doctrine declaring that US allies must provide their own ground troops?	☐	☐	☐	
63	What slogan did Richard Nixon use to describe his goal of achieving a negotiated exit from the war?	☐	☐	☐	
64	Which neutral country neighboring Vietnam did Nixon order a secret bombing campaign and ground invasion of in 1969-70?	☐	☐	☐	
65	Which country neighboring Vietnam was invaded by ARVN forces with US air support in 1971?	☐	☐	☐	
66	Which North Vietnamese capital city was hit by heavy U.S. B-52 bomber raids during the 1972 Christmas Bombings?	☐	☐	☐	
67	What was the official code name of the December 1972 Christmas Bombing campaign?	☐	☐	☐	
68	What was the main agreement reached in the Paris Peace Accords regarding US military forces?	☐	☐	☐	
69	Who was Nixon's National Security Advisor and lead negotiator at the Paris peace talks?	☐	☐	☐	
70	Who was the chief negotiator for North Vietnam who negotiated the peace accords with Henry Kissinger?	☐	☐	☐	
71	What was a major consequence of the withdrawal of US combat troops following the 1973 Paris Peace Accords?	☐	☐	☐	

Q#	The Target Question	R	A	G	Notes / My Answer
72	What was the term for Nixon's secret strategy to make North Vietnam think he was volatile and willing to use nuclear weapons?	☐	☐	☐	
73	Why did President Nixon order the military invasion of Cambodia in 1970?	☐	☐	☐	
74	What was the code name of the disastrous 1971 ARVN invasion of Laos that ended in panic and retreat?	☐	☐	☐	
75	What major conventional offensive did North Vietnam launch in spring 1972 to test the progress of Vietnamisation?	☐	☐	☐	
76	How many US and ARVN ground troops were committed to the ground invasion of Cambodia in April 1970?	☐	☐	☐	
77	Approximately how many tons of explosives were dropped on North Vietnam during the 1972 Christmas Bombings (Linebacker II)?	☐	☐	☐	
78	Which of the following best explains the main objective of Nixon's policy of 'Vietnamization'?	☐	☐	☐	
79	What was the most significant domestic consequence of Nixon's invasion of Cambodia in 1970?	☐	☐	☐	
80	Which of the following was the primary reason why President Nixon ordered the secret bombing of Cambodia in 1969?	☐	☐	☐	

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THE VAULT

Restricted Access: Answer Keys

KT 3.1: Why did the US support the unpopular government of Ngo Dinh Diem in South Vietnam?

1. Ho Chi Minh
2. Dien Bien Phu
3. 17th Parallel
4. The Domino Theory
5. Dwight D. Eisenhower
6. John F. Kennedy
7. Saigon
8. Hanoi
9. Ngo Dinh Diem
10. Strategic Hamlet Program
11. Vietminh
12. Buddhists
13. It forcibly relocated peasants from their ancestral lands and villages
14. Vietcong
15. National Liberation Front (NLF)
16. Thích Quảng Đức
17. It created the belief that if one country fell to communism, neighboring nations would quickly follow, threatening US security.
18. The end of French colonial rule in Indochina and the division of Vietnam at the Geneva Conference.
19. Widespread opposition to Ngo Dinh Diem's corrupt, anti-Buddhist, and repressive policies.
20. It backfired, increasing peasant resentment and boosting support for the Vietcong.

KT 3.2: Why did the US send combat troops to Vietnam after the Gulf of Tonkin incident?

21. USS Maddox
22. Gulf of Tonkin Resolution
23. It gave President Johnson authority to escalate US military involvement without a formal declaration of war
24. Operation Rolling Thunder
25. To destroy North Vietnam's transport infrastructure and disrupt supply routes
26. General William Westmoreland
27. Da Nang air base



KT 3.2: Why did the US send combat troops to Vietnam after the Gulf of Tonkin incident?



28. Pleiku
29. Over 500,000
30. Robert McNamara
31. It gave President Johnson the power to escalate military action without a formal declaration of war
32. Da Nang
33. Battle of Ia Drang
34. Two
35. Vo Nguyen Giap
36. The second attack was a 'phantom' event caused by weather and sonar errors, and never occurred
37. It gave the President blank-check authority to deploy combat troops without a formal declaration of war by Congress.
38. It marked the systematic escalation of the air war but failed to stop the flow of supplies from North Vietnam.
39. The imminent collapse of the South Vietnamese government and army under communist pressure.
40. It led to high US casualty rates and rising public opposition, without breaking the enemy's resolve.

KT 3.3: Why did US military tactics (like bombing and search & destroy) fail to defeat the Vietcong?

41. Guerrilla warfare
42. Search and Destroy
43. Napalm
44. Agent Orange
45. Ho Chi Minh Trail
46. Tunnel systems
47. Punji traps
48. Body count
49. UH-1 Huey
50. Tet Offensive
51. It shattered the public belief that the US was winning the war
52. Hue
53. Khe Sanh
54. US Embassy

KT 3.3: Why did US military tactics (like bombing and search & destroy) fail to defeat the Vietcong?

55. Zippo missions
56. 15,000 km
57. It allowed North Vietnam to continuously supply guerrillas in the South via routes in Laos and Cambodia.
58. It alienated the South Vietnamese peasantry, driving many to support the Vietcong.
59. They avoided large pitched battles, used complex tunnel networks, and blended in with the local peasant population.
60. They caused horrific civilian injuries and birth defects, turning international and domestic opinion against the war.

KT 3.4: What was Nixon's 'Vietnamization' policy, and did it achieve peace with honour?



61. Vietnamisation
62. Nixon Doctrine
63. Peace with Honor
64. Cambodia
65. Laos
66. Hanoi
67. Operation Linebacker II
68. All remaining US combat troops would withdraw, and North Vietnam would release all US POWs
69. Henry Kissinger
70. Le Duc Tho
71. Fighting resumed between North and South Vietnam, leading to the collapse of South Vietnam
72. Madman Theory
73. To destroy Vietcong supply sanctuaries and disrupt the Ho Chi Minh Trail
74. Operation Lam Son 719
75. Easter Offensive
76. 30,000 troops
77. 20,000 tons
78. To withdraw US troops while transferring combat responsibility to the South Vietnamese forces.
79. It triggered massive anti-war protests, including the Kent State shootings, and deep public outrage.
80. To destroy North Vietnamese sanctuaries and supply bases along the border.

Mastery Tracker

Track your total recall score across all 80 questions.

Attempt	Date	Score (/80)	Parent Validation Stamp	Target for Next Time
1			**PARENT VALIDATION STAMP** **Effort:** ⭐ ⭐ ⭐ (Circle 1–3) Date: _____ Signature: _____	
2			**PARENT VALIDATION STAMP** **Effort:** ⭐ ⭐ ⭐ (Circle 1–3) Date: _____ Signature: _____	
3			**PARENT VALIDATION STAMP** **Effort:** ⭐ ⭐ ⭐ (Circle 1–3) Date: _____ Signature: _____	

Operative Reflection

1. My ultimate strength in this unit is...

2. The three specific facts I need to hunt down and memorize tonight are...

3. Key targets and action steps for the next retrieval attempt: